



A PRABHAKAR RAO

the community's leaders.

Former Lok Sabha MP Basvaraj Yatnal, a known supporter of the chief minister's long-time rival Ananth Kumar, was suspended from the party for revolting against Yeddyurappa's leadership. There were murmurs of protest inside when his son Raghavendra was named to contest from Shimoga, although senior leaders had their own names, and reservations. Of course, the party leaders feared that Bangarappa would coast to victory on the strong support from his nearly two lakh-odd Idiga community members, but a sustained campaign by Yeddyurappa for his son helped pull off a big win for Raghavendra.

Another key weapon in the chief minister's arsenal is Operation Lotus—his programme to lure away more than a dozen leaders from the Congress and JD(S) who had the charisma to win on their own. And most of them did. Yeddyurappa terms his programme "political polarisation". In fact, a former Congress bigwig and Lingayat community leader V. Somanna, believed to be close to the 102-year-old revered Hindu pontiff and a famous Lingayat swamiji near Tumkur, was one of the big catches for Yeddyurappa under this programme. And Somanna's legwork helped the party triumph in Bangalore South.

"Leaders inspire leaders," says Somanna, who will be inducted into the Cabinet next week. Bangalore Rural MP and former chief minister Kumaraswamy derided this programme as a "murder of democracy by Yeddyurappa". "The seats that the party has won were by candidates' own merit and had nothing to do with their new party. These men could have won from any party." That does not bother Yeddyurappa, who began his political career with the Jan Sangh in early 1970s and delivered a knockout 110 seats in the May 2008 Assembly

polls with his five-month 9,000-mile "dharma yuddha" campaign.

The decreasing clout of the mining barons of Bellary—the Reddy brothers—was also evident in the near drubbing of the BJP candidate J. Shantha, sister of mining baron and state health minister B. Sriramulu. The Reddy brothers were so cocky in their campaign that they are still recovering from the shock of such a narrow margin in which the lone woman MP from the state made it to Parliament. It is also not a secret that the Reddy brothers, Janardhan and Karunakara, are Cabinet ministers and are very close to another powerful Reddy—Andhra Pradesh's chief minister YSR Reddy.

In biblical times, the children of Israel's arduous journey to the Promised Land took 40 years. That number is significant for the BJP in Karnataka too: in its former avatar Jan Sangh, it staged its political debut in 1968 in the coastal Karnataka town of Udupi. Today, the party has entered its own version of the Promised Land after almost four decades with 121 seats in the Assembly and 19 in the Lok Sabha. Karnataka

“I had promised Advani the highest number of seats from Karnataka. I really wanted him to be prime minister.”

B.S. YEDDYURAPPA,
Chief Minister, Karnataka

home minister V.S. Achar, who was the Udupi municipal chief on behalf of the Jan Sangh in 1968, says, "The fact that only the BJP can ensure stability in the state was evident in the support from the people in both last year's Assembly polls and even now."

For the BJP it has been an amazing journey to the Promised Land: from a mere 3.4 per cent vote share in 1985 to close to 35 per cent in 2008 and now nearly 42 per cent. For the time being, Yeddyurappa seems to be enjoying his post-poll success but he needs to watch out: his biggest detractors could be from within and not without. And it is time for his high rhetoric of "development, development, development" to translate into action rather than remain just words. ■